ADVANCE
FRONT AND CENTRE

26 September 2025

Committee Secretary
Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters
PO Box 6021
Parliament House
Canberra ACT 2600

Via email: em@aph.gov.au

Dear Committee Chair and members

RE: Inquiry into the 2025 federal election

ADVANCE welcomes the opportunity to contribute to the vital work of safeguarding our democracy and the integrity of our elections.

ADVANCE was founded in 2018 to be a voice for mainstream Australians who were being left behind as progressive activists imposed their agenda on our country. It was founded independently and was not set up by any corporation, non-government organisation, charity, think tank, or political party and remains independent to this day.

ADVANCE has since grown to one of Australia's largest grassroots movements with 493,130 supporters and 39,369 donors.

After the defeat of the divisive Voice to Parliament referendum, ADVANCE turned its attention to the 2025 Federal Election. Research and feedback from ADVANCE supporters showed that, despite starting out as an environmentalist party, the [redacted] were clearly not who they used to be. No major party or campaign group had ever fully targeted the [redacted] before, allowing them to grow across our parliaments, influencing policy in favour of anti-Australian extreme activists. ADVANCE's supporters decided enough was enough.

ADVANCE campaigned in key [redacted] held and target seats and the end result, known to the members of this Committee, was only one [redacted] MP left in the lower house and the defenestration of leader [redacted]. The full story of ADVANCE's [redacted] Truth campaign is found at Attachment A.

In the execution of this campaign, ADVANCE was not only active across a number of social media platforms, but also on the ground, delivering a sophisticated third-party field campaign in key target seats. It is the experience both in the virtual world and the real world that has informed this submission.

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The purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials.

The ADVANCE campaign was focussed on telling the truth about the [redacted] that the party was now a home for radical left ideology rather than an environmental protest movement. They didn't like ADVANCE's effective campaign and made that obvious in a variety of aggressive and unacceptable ways:

- **Shadowing and Disruption –** [redacted] campaigners frequently positioned themselves directly beside ADVANCE volunteers, often in uncomfortably close physical proximity, crowding them out and intercepting voters. This blocked access to undecided voters, reduced the visibility of campaign materials and signage, and created tension and confusion at critical moments.

  More concerningly, the close physical presence of these campaigners often took a psychological toll on many ADVANCE volunteers, especially those who were mature Australians, often involved in campaigning for the first time. The planned and deliberate nature of these activities meant that they generally ceased just prior to the point where volunteers would consider calling for police intervention. These actions had all the hallmarks of a deliberate strategy of intimidation.

- **Provocation by "plainclothes" supporters –** In an escalation of the activities outlined above, [redacted] supporters, wearing no campaign or volunteer identification but identified as such through their interactions with identifiable volunteers, posed as neutral voters to initiate confrontational exchanges. This was often coordinated with their campaign team before and after incidents. These confrontations, recorded by [redacted] volunteers, not only intimidated our volunteers, but generated hostile content for social media or complaints to AEC officials.

  Once again, these actions took a psychological toll on many ADVANCE volunteers, especially those campaigning for the first time.

- **Signage Saturation –** [redacted] signage was deployed early and in bulk to dominate visual space, with [redacted] volunteers positioned directly in front of ADVANCE signage to obscure it. This went beyond 'fair play' and the usual robust actions by all parties to secure the best locations for signage. These actions reflected deliberate acts to silence ADVANCE and avoid the truth we were telling about the [redacted]

- **Rostering Interference and Hijacking Attempts –** [redacted] aligned campaigners attempted to interfere with rostering by inserting themselves into sign-ups or exploiting public rostering tools. This caused operational confusion, misallocated volunteers and booth coverage, and obstructed ADVANCE's ability to coordinate effectively.

Consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour

There are clear, very precise, boundaries and limitations on the role and authority of the AEC in the *Commonwealth Electoral Act 1918*.

The most tangible of these is the 6-metre boundaries specified in section 340 of the Act dealing with the "prohibition of certain behaviour near polling booths and pre-poll voting places". Despite

the absolute clarity of these provisions, ADVANCE volunteers were directed, on more than one occasion, by AEC officials regarding what they could do outside that area.

In another situation, ADVANCE volunteers were directed not to hand out materials to voters as they were not representing a political party. Once again this was outside the 6-metre boundary but also reflected a further misunderstanding of the fundamental freedom for any person to campaign in a democracy.

In a different context again, AEC officials raised objections to campaign materials being distributed, outside the 6-metre boundary, by ADVANCE volunteers as they did not take the form of a traditional 'how to vote' card.

These examples of the most egregious errors by AEC officials were relatively isolated, but took far too long to resolve in what are elections that can be decided by increasingly narrow margins. They are also in addition to AEC officials not uncommonly applying, inappropriately, rules from State or Territory elections to the Federal election.

If there is to be any consideration of increased powers to the AEC, it must be clearly demonstrated that they have the capacity to exercise those powers appropriately and fairly. With the closest result in the election being decided by a mere 26 votes inappropriate interference by AEC officials that took a merely 30 minutes to resolve could easily see a result swayed.

The suitability of the current authorisation framework and requirements, having regard to the evolution of communication methods and technology

Through the recent Federal Election, ADVANCE was subject to repeated attention from the AEC regarding the authorisation of materials on social media.

The expectations communicated to ADVANCE often flew in the face of the practices of the major parties. Authorisations made by ADVANCE in a way identical to those of the [redacted] Party, [redacted] Party, [redacted] and [redacted] were indicated by the AEC as being non-compliant. ADVANCE changed authorisations following the AEC correspondence, yet we continued to observe the previous forms of authorisation being used by the major parties through the remainder of the campaign.

The AEC also sought to apply their *Authorisation placement, formatting, and language: Better practice guide* to materials in a precise and sometimes legalistic way that did not always reflect the requirements of the *Commonwealth Electoral Act 1918*. While this document is a very useful resource for which the AEC should be commended, its legalistic application at times undermined effective compliance.

There are also elements of that guide, and the AEC's approach, which are inconsistent with the current capabilities of specific platforms. The legislation seems to be bounded within a Facebook-style world that is not always possible in more contemporary platforms. The emphasis on full authorisations in every image when a clearly identified brand trademark or logo carries a very obvious indication of the source seems particularly redundant.

It certainly seemed at times that the AEC was seeking to "strain out a gnat" rather than the harder work of identifying and responding to those who hide behind anonymous accounts online to post unauthorised and potentially unlawful content. The Instagram, and other, accounts of the

offensive "Toilet Paper Australia", https://www.instagram.com/toiletpaperaustralia/, is one example of these sort of activities. Their posting of fraudulent and completely faked posts claimed to be made by ADVANCE has continued unchecked, despite notification of their activities to the AEC.

ADVANCE remains committed to the highest standards of integrity as it provides a voice for mainstream Australians. Freedom of speech, and especially political communication, is vitally important for our nation and to maintain the integrity of our elections and the confidence in those processes. ADVANCE will not be cowered by the actions of its opponents or the few AEC who brought their own political biases into their roles.

The actions of [redacted] supporters on the ground, and anonymous posters online, trying to shut down ADVANCE and its supporters went well beyond robust political communication and threatened this vital freedom. However, while on the receiving end of these unfair and unjust tactics, any 'solution' that increases the powers of the AEC brings with it significant risks. A politicised AEC imposing its view of what can and should be said in political debate would be the worst possible outcome.

The AEC has overwhelmingly operated with integrity in the 2025 Federal Election. There are improvements possible in their training and deployment of staff and resources, but these are at the margins. There is certainly no compelling case for wholesale changes to the *Commonwealth Electoral Act 1918* or the AEC electoral processes.

Yours faithfully

[redacted]

Matthew Sheahan
Executive Director